

SECONDARY DOMINANTS

Dominant chords built on non-diatonic roots — each one "tonicizes" a diatonic chord by placing a tritone-containing dominant just a P5 above it. Color category: BLUE.

DEFINITION

A **secondary dominant** is any dominant 7th chord placed a Perfect 5th above a diatonic chord (the "target"). Named V7/[target] — "five-seven of [target]." Contains a tritone that resolves directly into the target chord, creating a brief moment of tonicization.

ALL 6 SECONDARY DOMINANTS IN C MAJOR

NAME	SCALE DEG.	CHORD	INTERPOLATED II	RESOLVES TO
V7	5 G	G7	Dm7	Cmaj7 (I)
V7/ii	6 A	A7	Em7	Dm7 (ii)
V7/iii	7 B	B7	F#m7b5	Em7 (iii)
V7/IV	1 C	C7	Gm7	Fmaj7 (IV)
V7/V	2 D	D7	Am7	G7 (V)
V7/vi	3 E	E7	Bm7b5	Am7 (vi)

RESOLVING TO MAJOR CHORD

Use a **m7** as the interpolated ii chord

V7/IV: C7 – Gm7 because IV (Fmaj7) is Major

RESOLVING TO MINOR CHORD

Use a **m7b5 (half-dim)** as the interpolated ii

V7/vi: E7 – Bm7b5 because vi (Am7) is Minor

WHY V7/VII° DOESN'T EXIST

The vii° chord is diminished — already maximally unstable and built on the leading tone. A diminished chord cannot be "tonicized" because there's no stable tonal center to point toward. Creating a V7 of vii° would require pointing tension at something that has no harmonic gravity of its own. Diminished structures are devices, not tonal goals.